

"Love a Duck"

Raju lived in a very fine city. People came to **admire** the beautiful buildings, to shop at the **bustling** market, to enjoy the river and, most of all, to **feed** the ducks. Raju loved the ducks.

He lived with his little brown-eyed sister, Rashmi, on a houseboat **moored** near the great **cathedral**, and the ducks were his friends. They were special **Muscovy ducks**, black and white with red faces and **enormous** yellow feet. They didn't much care for swimming and **seldom** flew anywhere, so they **waddled** about accepting **scraps** of food from **passersby**.

Everybody loved them as much as Raju. Nearly everybody, that is.

Narayana Murthy was chairman of the council; he **ran** the town. He also had the biggest and shiniest boat on the river. In the evenings he would sit on **deck** with his friend George, eating and drinking, wearing a **Panama hat**, and looking important. He didn't like other people's boats nearby and he hated the ducks.



One day, when he was fishing, Raju heard Narayana Murthy talking to his friend. "We'll have to do something about it! Those **nasty**, dirty, horrible ducks have been **perching** on my boat again. Look at the paintwork! They're making the town a mess. I won't have it."

The very next day notices appeared all over town that read: "DO NOT FEED THE DUCKS – by order of the Council."

People couldn't believe it; they'd fed the ducks for years and now they must stop.

The ducks couldn't believe it either. **Starving**, they became pub ducks, superstore ducks, and garage forecourt ducks, living on what few scraps they could find. They became thin and their **feathers** got dirty. They lost all their spirit and their love of life.

But Narayana Murthy hadn't finished. Spring was coming: the **buds began to burst** and the first flowers appeared in the famous Jubilee Gardens by the river. One day Raju was fishing again, wearing his favourite David Beckham shirt and red baseball cap. He heard Narayana Murthy and George talking as they walked to Murthy's boat.



"It's spring, George, my boy," said Narayana Murthy. "You know what that means? I'll tell you what it means: it means more ducks. It's the **breeding** season. We can't have that."

"We must **look for** nests and take the eggs and that will be the end of it."

Raju was **devastated**; he ran to tell his little sister. "Rashmi, what can we do? This is terrible! The ducks will **die out**."

"I'll tell the ducks," she said, "they'll know what to do."

"It won't work — they won't understand!" Raju was **fighting back tears**.

"Maybe they will," she said.

But the ducks got fewer and fewer. They sat about in twos and threes looking lost and sad and lonely. **Meanwhile**, Narayana Murthy had become famous. His anti-duck campaign was headline news and one day a television company came to interview him. He **stood by** the duck-free river as it was being filmed and spoke to a young reporter.

"We did it without harming a single duck." Narayana Murthy smiled for the camera. "The city is now **rid of** these **vermin**. We have won the battle."

As he spoke there was clapping and cheering in the distance and, from gardens, sports fields, footpaths, and **alleys** came mother ducks with lines of yellow **ducklings** behind them. The father ducks quacked loudly with joy as they joined them. Proudly they waddled down to the river and launched their babies into the water where they **bobbed** and **paddled** in circles and chased **flies**, safe **at last**.

Rashmi was **jumping up and down**, her big brown eyes **sparkling** with tears of happiness. "See? It worked! It worked! I told the ducks to hide and they did. I told you they'd listen."

Raju gave her a big hug. "You were right. Clever you, clever ducks."

The **townsfolk**, **delighted** to see the return of their ducks, fed them, took photos and celebrated.

The reporter **looked about** as the cameraman shot pictures of happy ducks and cheering people for the prime time news. "It seems to



me, Mr Councillor, that the ducks have won the battle after all,” he said.

The next day the signs were gone. Narayana Murthy resigned from the council and moved his boat to another river. George went for a long holiday by the seaside. They were never seen in the city again.

Now people come from miles around to see the fine buildings, the towering cathedral, the famous mosques, and the bustling market—but most of all they come to feed the very special ducks that live there.

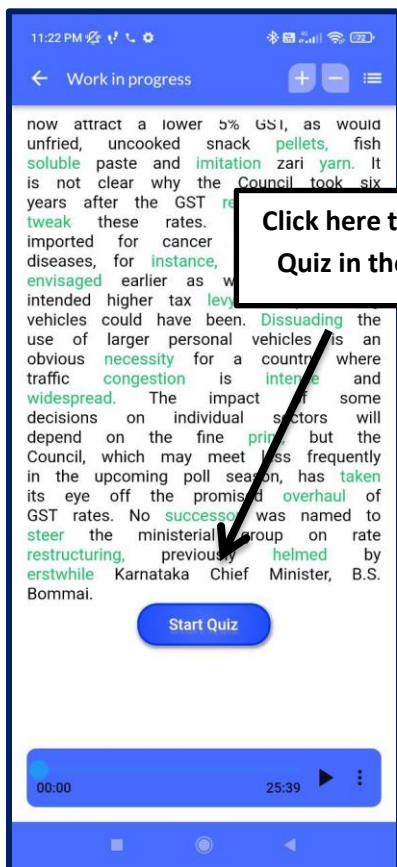
@mocks_wallah

Vocabulary

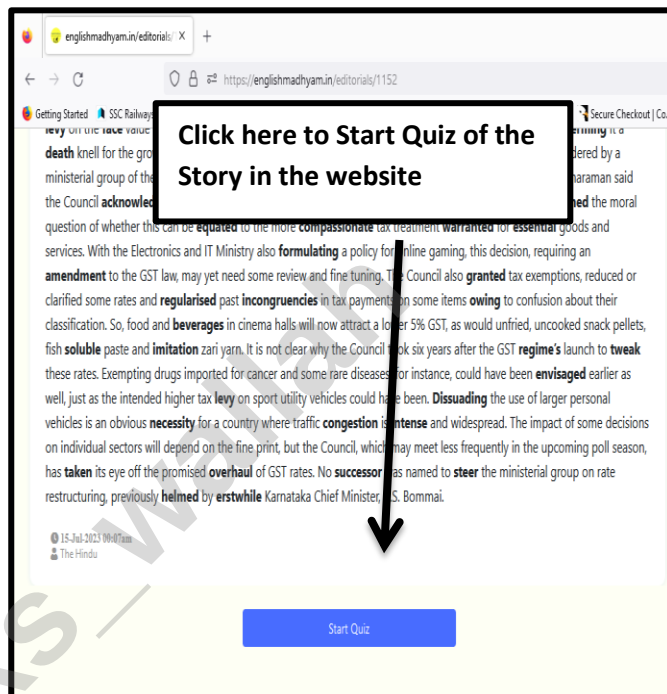
1. **Admire** (verb) – appreciate, respect, esteem, applaud, marvel at – प्रशंसा करना
2. **Bustling** (adjective) – lively, busy, vibrant, crowded, energetic – चहल-पहल वाला
3. **Feed** (verb) – nourish, provide for, supply, cater, sustain – खाना खिलाना
4. **Moor** (verb) – anchor, dock, tie up, berth, secure – नाव बांधना
5. **Cathedral** (noun) – church, basilica, abbey, temple, chapel – गिरजाघर
6. **Muscovy duck** (noun) – a type of large domesticated duck – एक विशेष प्रकार की बड़ी बत्तख
7. **Enormous** (adjective) – huge, massive, immense, gigantic, colossal – बहुत बड़ा
8. **Seldom** (adverb) – rarely, infrequently, occasionally, hardly, scarcely – शायद ही कभी
9. **Waddle** (verb) – toddle, shuffle, sway, hobble, stumble – लचकते हुए चलना
10. **Scrap** (noun) – bit, piece, fragment, morsel, leftover – टुकड़ा / झूठन
11. **Passerby** (noun) – pedestrian, onlooker, bystander, traveler, stranger – राहगीर
12. **Run** (verb) – manage, operate, govern, oversee, supervise – संचालित करना
13. **Deck** (noun) – platform, floor, terrace, patio, veranda – डेक / नाव का ऊपरी भाग
14. **Panama hat** (noun) – a traditional brimmed straw hat of Ecuadorian origin पनामा टोपी (एक हल्की टोपी)
15. **Nasty** (adjective) – unpleasant, mean, vile, dirty, disgusting – घिनौना / गंदा
16. **Perch** (verb) – rest, roost, sit, settle, alight – टिकना / बैठना
17. **Starve** (verb) – go hungry, famish, suffer from hunger, go without food, be malnourished – भूखा रहना
18. **Feather** (noun) – plumage, quill, down, fluff, pinion – पंख
19. **Bud began to burst** (phrase) – start blooming, open up, blossom, sprout – कली खिलने लगी
20. **Breeding** (adjective) – reproductive, mating, procreative, generative, fertility-related – प्रजनन संबंधी
21. **Look for** (phrasal verb) – search, seek, hunt, explore, try to find – तलाशना
22. **Devastate** (verb) – destroy, shatter, ruin, crush, wreck – बहुत दुखी करना / तबाह करना
23. **Die out** (phrasal verb) – become extinct, disappear, vanish, perish, fade away – विलुप्त हो जाना

24. **Fighting back tears** (phrase) – trying not to cry, holding back emotion – आँसू रोकना
25. **Meanwhile** (adverb) – in the meantime, simultaneously, at the same time – इस बीच
26. **Stand by** (phrasal verb) – remain near, wait, be present, be on hand – पास खड़ा रहना
27. **Rid** (of) (verb) – eliminate, remove, clear, free, purge – छुटकारा पाना
28. **Vermin** (noun) – pests, rodents, nuisances, harmful creatures, parasites – हानिकारक जानवर
29. **Alley** (noun) – lane, passageway, narrow street, walkway, byway – गली
30. **Duckling** (noun) – baby duck, young bird – बत्तख का बच्चा
31. **Bob** (verb) – float, bounce, dip, hop, nod – पानी पर हल्के-हल्के ऊपर-नीचे होना
32. **Paddle** (verb) – swim, wade, row, propel, splash – पंजों से पानी में चलना
33. **Flies** (noun) – insects, bugs, gnats, pests – मक्खियाँ
34. **At last** (phrase) – finally, eventually, in the end, ultimately – अंततः
35. **Be jumping up and down** (phrase) – be extremely excited, be thrilled, be overjoyed – खुशी से उछलना
36. **Sparkling** (adjective) – shining, twinkling, gleaming, bright, glistening – चमकता हुआ
37. **Townfolk** (noun) – residents, citizens, locals, townspeople, community – शहरवासी
38. **Delight** (verb) – please, charm, thrill, gladden, satisfy – आनंदित करना
39. **Look about** (phrasal verb) – glance around, observe, scan, survey, look around – इधर-उधर देखना

Practice Exercise



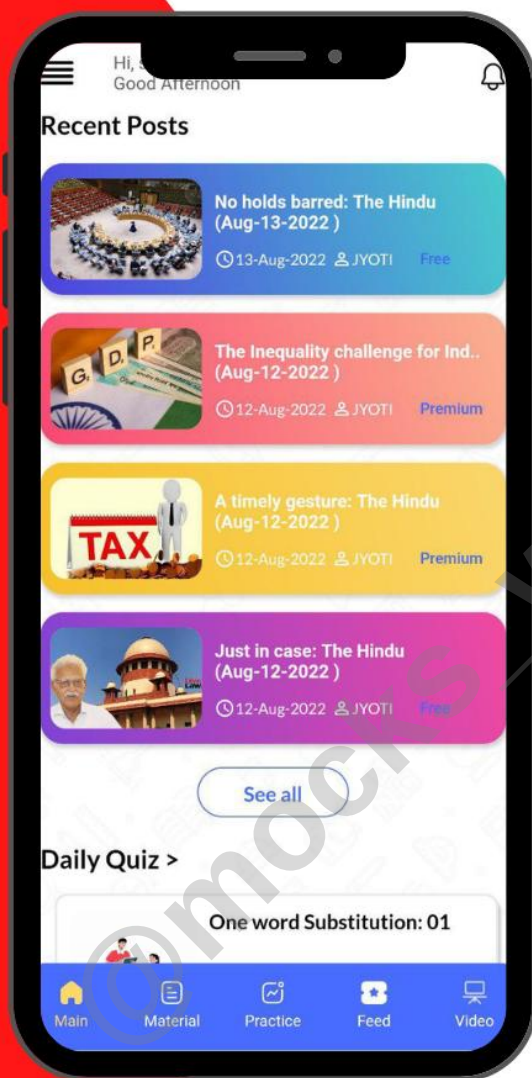
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